Understand the User, Don't Repeat: Linguistic Cues of Unmet Needs and Explicit Repair in Task-Oriented Dialogue

Ying Chen

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Abstract

When a dialogue system fails, users seldom say so in emotional words. They repeat the request, rephrase it, write "what?", or get shorter. We study these cues in EmoWOZ, a corpus with emotion labels on every user turn. Human operators change their replies after a dissatisfied turn (acknowledgment rises from 3.9% to 17.8%); a deployed machine system does not (3.7% vs. 3.5%). Toward the machine, 46.8% of dissatisfied turns repeat an earlier request, and only 7.7% contain a complaint or negation word, so word-level sentiment misses most of them. We then ask whether a language model can be made to answer the unmet need rather than the last message. Asking the model to "read the user first" helps a strong model but hurts an 8B model, which misreads the need and apologizes instead of delivering. We propose REPAIR, which reads the dialogue explicitly — repair cues, a ledger of requested, delivered and pending items, and database rows for the pending item — and hands this reading to the generator. On 100 unseen dialogues, REPAIR raises how well an 8B model resolves the user's need from 0.45 to 1.22 on a 0–2 scale, cuts the share of replies after which the user would likely give up from 49% (prompt-only reading) to 19%, and brings the 8B model to the level of a much stronger model given a "be concrete" instruction.

1 Introduction

A user who has asked twice for a guesthouse in the south does not need a third question about the price range, and does not need an apology. The user needs the guesthouse. Dialogue systems, including systems built on large language models, are usually asked to respond to the last message. When an earlier request is still open, the last message is often a repetition ("hotel", "hotel options", "four star hotels"), and a system that answers it in isolation repeats its own failure.

Conversation analysis calls these moves *other-initiated repair*: the listener signals that something was not understood or not delivered and invites the speaker to fix it [Schegloff et al., 1977]. In the terms of Clark and Brennan [1991], the request has not been grounded. Our view is that unmet needs are visible mostly in this linguistic behaviour — repetition, rephrasing, repair tokens, shortening — and only partly in emotional vocabulary. Earlier work by the author on offensive language took the same position: lexical and syntactic structure, together with a user's writing style, carried most of the signal [Chen et al., 2012].

This paper makes three contributions. (1) A corpus study on EmoWOZ [Feng et al., 2022] showing that a machine system does not react to dissatisfaction, and that users express dissatisfaction to it mainly by repeating requests. (2) A negative result: telling a model to infer the user's state from the dialogue helps a strong model and hurts a small one. (3) REPAIR, an explicit

reading of repair cues and pending needs, grounded in the task database, which makes a small model resolve the user's need far more often on unseen dialogues. We release code, prompts and all model outputs.

2 Related Work

Emotion in task-oriented dialogue. EmoWOZ labels every user turn of MultiWOZ [Budzianowski et al., 2018] and of 1,000 human–machine dialogues (DialMAGE) with one of seven emotions [Feng et al., 2022]. Recent work detects frustration in deployed task-oriented systems [fru, 2024] and studies emotion in customer-service dialogue, finding that apology and empathy often leave anger in place [emo, 2025]. These works detect the state; we study how it is expressed and how to act on it.

Repair and grounding. Our cue set follows the repair literature [Schegloff et al., 1977] and grounding theory [Clark and Brennan, 1991].

LLM judges. LLM judges have known biases [Zheng et al., 2023]; we report one more in task dialogue: they reward confident, invented bookings.

3 Corpus Study

EmoWOZ has two parts: MultiWOZ, where a human "wizard" plays the system (10,438 dialogues), and DialMAGE, where a machine system talks to people (995 dialogues). We call a user turn *negative* if it is labelled dissatisfied or abusive. Confidence intervals are 95% bootstrap intervals over dialogues (2,000 resamples).

The machine does not react. We match apology and acknowledgment words (*sorry, apologize, my mistake, I understand*, …) in the system's next reply. Human wizards use them after 17.8% of negative turns and 3.9% of neutral turns. The machine: 3.5% and 3.7%. Including *unfortunately / I'm afraid*: wizards 20.3% [17.7, 22.7] vs. 5.4%; machine 5.0% [4.2, 5.8] vs. 5.6% [5.0, 6.3].

Dissatisfaction is expressed by repeating. Table 1 shows, for each negative turn, whether it contains a complaint or negation word, and whether it repeats an earlier request of the same user (token Jaccard ≥ 0.5).

	n	complaint word	repeats own request	neither
MultiWOZ, negative turns	958	53.0%	3.0%	44.6%
DialMAGE, negative turns	4,264	7.7%	46.8%	47.6%
DialMAGE, neutral turns	7,230	3.0%	13.2%	84.2%

Table 1: How dissatisfaction is expressed. With a human wizard users complain in words; with a machine they repeat themselves.

When the machine repeats its own previous reply (Jaccard ≥ 0.8) after a negative turn, the next user turn is still negative 88.3% [80.0, 95.7] of the time, against 54.6% [52.7, 56.6] otherwise ($n = 71$ repeats).

4 REPAIR

REPAIR (Reading Escalation And Pending Items for Response) builds a short, checkable reading of the dialogue at the current user turn. It is deterministic and uses no model calls.

1. **Repair reader.** Cues in the last user turn: repetition (Jaccard ≥ 0.5 with an earlier user turn) or rephrasing (0.3–0.5); repair tokens (*what?*, *??*, *I said*, *already*); negation (*no, not, again, still*); talk about the conversation (*can you help*, *understand*); a turn under half the user's median length; give-up words. These map to an escalation stage 0–4.

2. **Grounding ledger.** For each domain (restaurant, hotel, attraction, train, taxi, …), the constraints the user stated, whether a matching entity was delivered by the system afterwards, and which required details are missing (train: origin, destination, day; taxi: origin, destination, time). Turns without domain words refine the current domain; a bare answer fills the slot the system asked for; negated needs ("does not need wifi") remove a constraint. Only the current topic is shown.

3. **Database grounding.** Rows from the MultiWOZ database that match the pending request; if none, constraints are relaxed one at a time (type and amenities first) and the relaxation is stated.

4. **Policy.** By stage: deliver the pending item first; ask only for missing required details; book when asked; at stage 4, say what can and cannot be done and offer a human.

The reading is appended to the dialogue, together with the system's last turns marked "do not repeat". Any generator can use it.

5 Experiments

Cases. From DialMAGE we take every dialogue at the first user turn that is negative and repeats an earlier request: the need is still unmet. We developed prompts and the reader on 60 cases of the test split, and on 81 cases of the dev split for a second round; the results we report are on 100 cases from the train split, which were not looked at during development.

Conditions. A: reply to the last message. B: be concrete, answer rather than ask back. C: prompt-only reading — find what is unresolved from the same linguistic cues and how the user feels, then deliver it (for the 8B model, two calls: read, then reply). D: REPAIR. E: REPAIR without stage, cues and policy (ledger and database only).

Generators. Claude Sonnet (via the `claude` CLI) and Llama 3 8B (dolphin-llama3:8b via ollama). A–C have no database; D and E have the rows REPAIR selects.

Evaluation. A judge model sees the dialogue and the five replies in random order, and scores each reply: *resolves* (0 does not, 1 partly, 2 delivers the need), *give_up* (a user in this state would likely give up), *repeats*, and the best reply. The judge is Claude Opus. In a second pass the judge also sees the database rows for the current request and is told that a contradicting fact cannot score 2. An objective check without any model asks whether the reply names a real database entity that satisfies the pending constraints. Differences are paired bootstrap 95% intervals over cases.

Llama 3 8B	resolves	give up	best	real & matching
A last message	0.45	29%	8%	23.0%
B be concrete	0.45	28%	12%	21.8%
C prompt-only reading	0.33	49%	9%	18.4%
D REPAIR	**1.22**	**19%**	**37%**	60.9%
E ledger + database	1.16	23%	34%	62.1%
D, fact-checked judge	1.41	14%	50%	
B, fact-checked judge	0.17	56%	2%	

Table 2: 100 unseen DialMAGE dialogues, Llama 3 8B generator, Claude Opus judge. "Real & matching" is over the 87 cases with a database request.

5.1 Results

Small model. REPAIR resolves the need far more often than every baseline (Table 2): D−B +0.77 [0.55, 0.98], D−C +0.89 [0.70, 1.08], and the share of give-ups falls by 30 points against prompt-only reading [−42, −18]. Prompt-only reading is the worst condition: inspecting 18 development cases where it lost, the model's own reading named needs from earlier in the dialogue or invented them ("Indian restaurant" for a guesthouse request), and the reply apologized and promised ("please bear with me") instead of delivering. The same pattern held on the 81 dev-split cases (D 1.10 vs. C 0.57).

Strong model. With Claude Sonnet, prompt-only reading is already strong: resolves C 1.45, D 1.34, B 1.25, A 0.83 (D−C −0.11 [−0.28, 0.05]); give-ups C 2%, D 18%. REPAIR raises real, matching entities from 52.9% (C) to 67.8% and cuts entities that violate the user's constraints from 33.3% to 13.8%. This judge is from the same model family as the generator. [PENDING: fact-checked judge on Claude runs; second judge family]

Small model with REPAIR vs. strong model. On the same 100 cases and the same judge, Llama 8B with REPAIR (1.22) is close to Claude Sonnet told to be concrete (1.25) and above Claude answering the last message (0.83). The two were judged in separate passes.

What carries the gain. D and E do not differ significantly (resolves −0.06 [−0.19, 0.07] for the 8B model): the explicit ledger and the database account for the improvement; the stage policy has not shown a separate effect.

Judges reward invented bookings. Without the database, the judge gave full marks to a reply that "booked" train TR0899 for a Leicester–Cambridge request; in the database TR0899 runs Cambridge–London. Showing the judge the database rows removes this: B falls from 0.45 to 0.17 for the 8B model, D rises from 1.22 to 1.41. Because the rows come from the same reader REPAIR uses, we report both passes.

6 Limitations

No human evaluation yet [PENDING: 30–50 cases, agreement with the judge]. One judge model family [PENDING: Gemini or GPT judge]. The repair cues and the complaint-word list are lexical

and have not been validated against hand labels [PENDING: reader accuracy on a labelled sample]. All machine dialogues come from one corpus (DialMAGE). The database is static and booking is simulated. The objective check depends on the reader's own reading of the pending request.

7 Conclusion

Users tell a system it has failed mostly by repeating themselves, and systems answer the repetition instead of the need behind it. Making that need explicit — what was asked, what was delivered, what is still pending, with real data to deliver it — lets a small model do what a strong model does from a prompt, and makes both deliver real, correct entities more often.

Reproducibility. Code, prompts, model outputs and judgments: `https://github.com/yingchen-coding/frustration-paper`.

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